

A Brand NEW LIFE

A unique initiative in Jharkhand rescues tribal girls from being trafficked and gives them dignity and jobs

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Sushma Kumari, 18, is brimming with confidence as she declares: "I can beat a burglar to pulp." Wearing her new security guard's uniform and twirling a baton, she is preparing to leave for Delhi to join the security staff at Jharkhand Bhawan, the office of the state's resident commissioner. For the young tribal girl, a resident of Chanhoo in Ranchi district, life has changed so much in last few months. The eldest in a poor family of seven, the pressure to earn for the family forced her to accompany a distant relative to Mumbai in 2004 where she was given a job as a housemaid where she was regularly beaten up and often left hungry. When the torture became unbearable, Sushma ran away only to be hauled up by the police and sent back to Ranchi, where she returned penniless. The employers had paid her nothing as the money had gone to an agent who deals in trafficking young women.

She is one of the many young girls from Jharkhand who have been rehabilitated in society by a unique project run by Action against Trafficking and Sexual Exploitation of Children (ATSEC). In her new job, Sushma will be paid Rs 5,000 plus free accommodation. ATSEC, Jharkhand, convenor Sanjay Kumar Mishra is executing the rehabilitation programme where the

victims of human trafficking are trained by Bhartiya Kisan Sangh (BKS) as security guards and in housekeeping activities. The project is supported by the UN Office on Drugs and Crime and Jharkhand Police. Jharkhand Labour Commissioner Aradhana Patnaik says that the state intends to give permanent employment to more trafficked girls. "Besides, the Confederation of Indian Industry has helped us place a majority of girls as security guards in industrial units and hotels," says Mishra.

The first batch of 25 tribal girls has already been trained by BKS for the hospitality industry while the second batch is attending classes. Earlier, the BKS had provided special combat training for 140 girls and many of them guard the Birsas Stadium in Ranchi. Similarly, six more tribal girls like Beena Kujur, rescued from differ-

ent parts of the country, have assumed charge of the VVIP guesthouse at Khelgaon, Hotwar Ranchi. All these girls have similar stories: a troubled childhood, poor families, livelihood pressure and desperate for employment. Because they were in situations of instability, a good number trusted acquaintances who used the opportunity to exploit them. In most cases, the promised salary was never paid and the girls were shuttled from one house to other. Their troubles, however, remained unchanged even after the change of address till they ran away or were rescued by police and sent home where the welcome was hardly a warm one. In fact, returning home often marked the beginning of a new crisis, as the girls—hundreds in number—had returned with nothing but scars of physical abuse or were victims of sexual exploitation.

